the women and children who would have no one to defend them. She was almost too afraid to ask what had happened to them. “Are they still there?”

“Last month I went to visit . . .” His voice turned hollow. “French gendarmes were forcibly separating the children from their mothers and then loading the women onto trains also destined for Poland.”

Anger burned in her chest. Why did it seem that Maître Mallon was the only one who didn’t go along with the sorting and shipping of people as though they were packages and not human beings? She imagined the tears and cries of fear as the children were torn from their parents and then sent away on a train. “And now the children are alone?”

“Yesterday, they too were sent East by convoy.”

Shame for her country flooded through her. She couldn’t understand the cruelty that existed in the hearts of the men who carried this out. She looked at the letter, which once would have made her proud, and tore it in two. “I’m sorry, but I will never work at another notary office. Never.”

“You shouldn’t—”

“I’ll become a cleaner like Rose.” Some of the women at the boardinghouse had urged Rose to join them at the Salbris arms factory because the salaries were high and the hours good, but neither she nor Léa could bring themselves to work for the enemy.

“Léa,” he said. “You’re an intelligent young woman with your whole life ahead of you. You have more to offer . . .”

She sighed. The Occupation had woven a thread of greed through society. Everyone was out for themselves. She didn’t know how it would end or what they would all become when it did.

“Cleaning is work I can be proud of,” she told him. “I will never have anything to do with disposing of and selling innocent people’s property and then shipping them out of the country.” Everyone said that bad things occurred in Paris or Lyon, the big cities, not here—they were lying to themselves. Their eyes were open, but they didn’t want to see what was happening in front of them, because it would mean they were a part of it.

“I’ll write another recommendation letter, in case you change your mind.”

“No. I’ll be fine.” Her voice softened. “Thank you.”

He looked at her over his glasses. “I respect you for the kindness you show others, your discipline and work ethic.” He drew a breath. “But war